

Caught in Quota Warp Poor Show

MINISTRY OF HRD

(DEPARTMENT OF SCHOOL EDUCATION AND LITERACY)

Staff: **424**

Wages and allowances: **Rs 7.01 crore**

Total plan and non-plan expenditure: **Rs 23,142.22 cr**

RATIONALE: Universalisation of elementary education, that is, to promote education and adult literacy at primary and secondary school levels.

REALITY CHECK: The omnibus ministry created by Rajiv Gandhi by merging Education, Culture, Women and Child, Sports and Youth Welfare has been dismantled into as many ministries, negating any logic of efficiency and delivery that he might have desired.

While Culture and Women and Child Development can claim to have some legitimacy for existence, Education is as much a state subject as federal, especially school education and adult literacy. You could argue that primary education in some states requires a push from the Centre, but its report card is stained with failure. In government, spend is never equal to the result. At HRD, even the spend is inefficient. This year, for instance, the department was left with Rs 1,453.76 crore under Elementary Education and Literacy as on February 28. Even under the Education Guarantee Scheme, it

achieved only 52 per cent of its target of

47.7 lakh enrolments. The two elaborate schemes launched by the HRD Ministry—the Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan and the Mid-day Meal scheme—have so far remained peripheral in developing these sectors, as implementation is in the hand of the states.

Tamil Nadu has successfully

experimented with the Mid-day Meal Scheme, leading to a healthy growth from the 1960s onwards, while Central funding for primary education has resulted in a colossal waste in most states, as they tend to underutilise and experiment with the funds. Adult literacy, as the Kerala experiment has shown, is best left to the states. If the HRD must involve itself in policy, it should only be at the higher education level, although after the quota imbroglio, that too is open to debate. It would be best if the ministry focused on opening up higher education. That would force all states to sit up and design their school syllabi to suit the needs of a modern economy.

MINISTRY OF HOUSING AND URBAN POVERTY ALLEVIATION

Staff: **139**

Wages and allowances: **Rs 2.59 crore**

Total plan and non-plan expenditure: **Rs 509.75 crore**

RATIONALE: To shape the policies and programmes of the country as a whole, allocate resources, provide finances through national financial institutions for housing and urban development.

REALITY CHECK: Poverty alleviation should be the focus of all policies. This ministry was designed to provide affordable urban housing and create jobs. If the mushrooming of slums or the absence of a framework to create jobs is any indicator, the ministry has failed miserably.

Created on October 16, 1999, merged in 2000, and re-formed on May 27, 2004, this ministry, like many others, exists as an instrument of political accommodation. All matters pertaining to housing and urban development are assigned to states and by the 74th Amendment to the Constitution, to urban local bodies. The constitutional and legal authority of the Centre is limited to Delhi and the Union territories. Even if one were to argue the case for Central intervention, neither the structure of governance nor the ministry's performance would justify it. The Centre can draw up policy, but as long as implementation is with the states, results cannot be guaranteed. The number of urban poor was estimated at 80.7 million by a National Sample Survey Organisation (NSSO) study in 2004 and housing shortage at 24.71 million units in March 2007.

The joke is, the ministry estimates only 42 million of the 285 million urban dwellers live in slums. As for poverty alleviation, it has the Swarna Jayanti Shahari Rozgar Yojana. The ministry told Parliament that allocation had been hiked from Rs 160 crore in 2005-06 to Rs 344 crore in 2007-08. That is Rs 43 per urban poor per year. To get a sense of the magnitude of work, consider these statistics: the ministry told Parliament that it assisted just 469 urban poor in Delhi in three years—133 in 2003-04, 181 in 2004-05 and 149 in 2005-06. Perhaps it couldn't find poverty in Delhi.

